

Lesson 6: You're Going to Have to Get Over That

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When I first got to Tennessee, we had a team meeting and, you know, you walk into this amazing locker room and you sit down with all the rest of your teammates and it's the very first meeting. And Pat was obviously in the front of the room explaining what the notebook was on the table in front of us. And it said, Pat's definite dozen. And the Definite Dozen was not only Definite Dozen, but it was like the rules and regulations. And it was this thick. It was very thick.

And so, you know, she starts going through like, you know, about eye contact and you'll be to class on time in the first three rows and like typical Pat fashion. So she goes through the Definite Dozen and why they're important and talks about how people that go before you, that have come before you, meaning the whole Title IX stories, she used that as an example of people that have paved the way for you before you even were able to sit in this really plush, nice locker room.

She goes, and you will be leaders on and off the court. You have a responsibility to speak. You have a responsibility to introduce yourself, to be confident young women at all times. You'll sign autographs to fans, to the University of Tennessee, to the state of Tennessee, the city of Knoxville.

So, then she said, again, you'll have to introduce yourself. So I sort of froze at this moment because what she didn't know and what nobody knew except me is that I grew up with a stuttering problem. And so I and I was made fun of terribly and I just didn't really know how to like work my way through that. And I just wanted to play basketball. But when she said, you'll stand up, you'll be a leader, you'll introduce yourself, you'll all this kind of stuff. I just started and I totally zoned out everything else that was happening.

So that being the backstory, I went up to Pat after this meeting and I said, "Pat, I need to talk to you." And she said, "When is your class tomorrow?" I said, "It's 8 a.m." She goes, "Where is it?" And I say, "It's at the Hyper Building." So she said, "I'll meet you on the track in the bleachers."

So 7.45, 7.30 comes. I meet Pat. She sits down next to me and she just looks at me and goes, "What's up?" And I mean, true Pat fashion. I said, "There's something I need to talk to you about." And I think I think she may have thought, like, because of the serious tone in my body language, I think she thought that I was going to tell her I was like pregnant or like something like I can't do this. And this is why. No, I just said, "So I don't know exactly how to say this, but I have a stuttering problem and I have a fear of speaking. So like introducing myself and I said, that is extremely difficult for me and I don't like to do it. And it's not something that I don't think I can do."

She just kind of looked at me very, very perplexed and said, "Is that all?" And I said, "Yeah, that's it." She looked out on the track. She looks back at me and goes, "Well, you're going to have to get over that." She patted me on the knee twice, you know, like a parent would and like pats me on the shoulder and says, "All right, get to class." That was it. That was the extent of the interaction.

This struggle that I've had my whole life speaking, I've had to always get over it. And that was a probably a really great learning. I didn't like her for it, but it was a great turning point for me to have the courage to face your fears. And for me, it was always it's always been speaking and to face your fears and just sort of tackle whatever you're scared of head-on and get over it.